## 6.1. Preparing for analysis: generating the richest set of data you can

The nature of production monitoring systems is to do real-time analysis on data for quick feedback on software systems so you don't have to do much to get data from them. Even with the most low-touch system, there are techniques you can apply to collect better data that provides insight into its performance and how it's being used by your consumers.

A lot of the advice that you're about to read crosses the line into BI. Understanding how your consumer is using your site is key to ensuring you're building the right product and adding the right features at the right time. I've been on several teams where BI was a separate organizational function that didn't always communicate directly with the development team, and that feedback certainly didn't come back to the team directly after they released updates to the consumer. If possible, BI should be integrated tightly with the development team; the closer the two functions are to one another, the better the tactics described in the next subsections will work.

**The difference between BI and business success metrics**

Even though I'm advocating keeping the BI effort closely tied to your development effort, it makes sense to have BI as a separate function from application development. BI teams exist to crunch the data your application generates, looking for trends and figuring out how different things affect each other. BI teams generate reports that show trends and relationships that reflect how the data being generated affects the success of the business. Success metrics reflect how your application is being used and are the indicators of consumer behavior that are unique to your application.

### 6.1.1. Adding arbitrary metrics to your development cycle

It is not uncommon that a team will get caught up in building, and even testing, a feature and then leave any possible instrumentation or tagging for